

The Appeal

La Recherche / Atelier Nymphet

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By the time the appeal learned how to type, the sentence was already bodily.

A case file likes to pretend its chronology is the only chronology. Verdict, sentence, notice, record, briefing, hearing. The body keeps another calendar. Humiliation. Custody. Waiting. Paper. The legal sequence kept its own order, but by February 13, 2023 Daniel was not experiencing his future as doctrine. He was experiencing it as email.

Appeals.

Then Fwd: Appeals.

Then RE: Appeals.

The higher chamber first reintroduced itself not as rescue, but as subject line. Bureaucracy can take a human catastrophe and make it dress for office.

At 3:35 p.m. on February 13, Daniel wrote to McClintock Law Firm because Susan Chadderdon had referred him there with regard to appealing his felony stalking case. The nouns were already wearing handcuffs. A felony stalking case. As if language itself had agreed to stand still while the state pinned labels on it. He wrote that he understood the process did not begin until after sentencing, but wanted to better understand how they proceed. He was asking for a way back into a future that had already been mislabeled.

The answer came eleven minutes later, which is either efficiency or the speed that reminds you calamity is never as singular to the professionals as it is to you. Geoffrey Wolter, assistant to Elizabeth McClintock, asked for a case number and any other pertinent information. He would be happy to help arrange a time to speak with Ms. McClintock.

Happy to help. Arrange a time. Pertinent information.

Before the law will reconsider your life, it wants intake first. A case number. A consultation. A box with a reference number on the side.

Daniel wrote back with 2022CR002416, and then because no one had yet taught him the difference between a story and an issue, he gave them the living version. He described the fiancée who had stopped talking to him. The messages. The flowers. The love poems read in monotone and mocked. The broadness of the law. The deputy already infected by prior rumor. Old tenderness, grievance, community appetite, and state power kneaded into felony.

It was too much, and it was exactly what he had.

The narrowing had begun. In the human world, appeal sounds roomy, like a wiser room farther uphill where fuller language may still be admitted if you knock hard enough. In the legal world, appeal wants a transcript, a sentencing date, a consultation, and error slim enough to pass through a procedural keyhole. It asks not whether a life was flattened, but whether flattening followed choreography.